WHAT IS THE TOP WINTER DESTINATION IN YOUR STATE?



Rajgir, the ancient capital city of Magadha, known for its warm water ponds, is a top winter destination in Bihar. Rajgir abounds in monuments and places that can enrich the traveller's knowledge and experiences that can thrill anybody. Home to some beautiful Hindu and Jain temples, Rajgir attracts scores of Hindus and Jains. Added to this, a nature safari has also come up here–this includes a glass skywalk in a natural environment, a suspension bridge, a zip line cycle, an adventure park, a butterfly zone and a nature camp area."

–NARAYAN PRASAD, Tourism Minister, Bihar



"Uttarakhand is focusing on both the religious and adventure tourism sectors. The infrastructure is in place to receive tourists in the Char Dham–Ukhimath (winter seat of Lord Kedarnath and Madhyamaheshwar), Pandukeshwar (Udhava Idol, the emissary of Lord Bari), Khushimath (winter home of Goddess Yamunotri) and Ukhwa (winter home to Goddess Gangotri) near Harsil. We are also pushing Auli winter sports in a big way."

–SATPAL MAHARAJ, Tourism Minister, Uttarakhand

WHAT WILL BE THE HIGHLIGHTS OF TOURISM IN YOUR STATE NEXT YEAR?



The new tourism policy gives lot of weight to developing experiential tourism products and new offbeat destinations such as Banswara, Dholpur, Deeg, Bharatpur, the Shekhawati area, etc. Ranging from desert biking to chopper rides, adventure tourism activities are emerging in several areas of the state and with the launch of our rural tourism policy, we are expecting that rural areas of Rajasthan would be a major attraction in coming years."

–VISHVENDRA SINGH, Tourism Minister, Rajasthan



Karnataka's variety of eco-tourism destinations–wildlife sanctuaries, hill stations, waterfalls, reservoirs and beaches–will continue to be a highlight. Nandi Hills is a key destination we shall be focusing on in the coming year. Six cities–Bengaluru, Mysuru, Mangaluru, Hubballi, Kalaburagi, and Ballari–shall also act as hubs for heli-tourism from which helicopters will cover other destinations across the state."

–PANKAJ KUMAR PANDEY, Tourism Secretary, Karnataka

Reaching for the Stars



Until recently, Meena Bagh Ratnari offered its guests the "surreal experience" of living smack in the middle of an apple orchard with cats, dogs, sheep, chicken and ducks for company. Some 85 km from Shimla, the four-bedroom Himachali bungalow is where you went for the vistas and the tranquillity. Earlier this month, Sanjay Austa, Meena Bagh's owner, decided to double up the delights of his farmstay. The 20-inch Dobsonian telescope he has installed in Ratnari is India's largest privately owned telescope. A journalist and photographer, Austa is an astronomy enthusiast and hopes the telescope will help his property earn a new reputation as an observatory: "We are an offbeat location, so with the observatory, we hope to attract the kind of travellers who are interested in nature, mountains, the sky and stars." ■